Two Thousand Years of Relationship Advice. Still No Shortcut.

09/18/2026

By Warren Tingen and Brett Hunsaker

Brett Hunsaker's favorite book on relationships is *Mr. Shmooze* — a short parable about a salesman whose entire method is giving more than he takes. The ideas in it are much older than that.

So we went looking for the rest of the lineage, and came back with a reading list running from Seneca to Adam Grant. Two thousand years of people working the same problem: how do you get another human being to trust you?

Here's what makes it urgent now. Everyone is taking the easy route. AI drafts the follow-up, summarizes the call, and remembers the name of the CFO's daughter so you don't have to. Useful. Not the same thing.

AI can support a relationship. It cannot have one. You still have to go out and touch somebody.

What follows is the distilled version — the principles that keep surfacing no matter which century you're reading in, and the book each one came from.

Give before you ask

Mr. Shmooze, Richard Abraham (2002)

Abraham's whole premise is that selling, done properly, isn't taking and isn't even persuading. It's giving. Mr. Shmooze leads with what he can do for you, and the business follows him around because of it.

In our world that looks like sending the comp nobody asked for. Making the introduction that earns you nothing. The ledger stays closed, or people will feel you keeping it.

Become genuinely interested in other people

How to Win Friends and Influence People, Dale Carnegie (1936)

Carnegie's line is that you make more friends in two months by being interested in people than in two years trying to make them interested in you. Ninety years later, nobody has improved on it.

What is telling is the second question. Anyone can ask about the kids once. Interest is asking about the kid by name, in March, about the thing they mentioned in October.

Relationships are built between the opportunities

Endless Referrals, Bob Burg (1993)

The deal is not the relationship. The deal is a moment inside the relationship. What determines whether there's a next one is everything that happens in the eighteen months when there's nothing on the table.

The call with no agenda is the most underrated move in this business. It's also the one that makes most people uncomfortable, which is exactly why a call without an agenda works.

Dig your well before you're thirsty

Dig Your Well Before You're Thirsty, Harvey Mackay (1997)

Mackay's title does the whole job. The network you need in a bad market is the one you built in a good one.

Nobody wants to hear from you for the first time when you need something. And people can always tell — the ask arriving with the introduction is its own kind of announcement.

Seek first to understand, then to be understood

The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People, Stephen Covey (1989)

Covey's fifth habit is the one most professionals skip, because listening feels like giving up ground. It isn't. Most people are reloading while the other person talks.

In a negotiation, the party who can articulate the other side's position better than they can usually ends up shaping the outcome.

Be a go-giver, not a go-getter

The Go-Giver, Burg and Mann (2007); Give and Take, Adam Grant (2013)

Burg and Mann tell it as a parable. Grant went and gathered the data, and the data agrees: over a full career, generous operators outperform purely self-interested ones.

The catch is that it only works if the generosity is real. Strategic generosity with a payback schedule is just a slower transaction, and everyone recognizes it.

Make people feel important — and mean it

How to Win Friends and Influence People, Dale Carnegie (1936)

Carnegie was explicit that this fails the moment it becomes technique. Flattery is counterfeit and people cash it accordingly.

The honest version is easier anyway. Everyone you deal with is genuinely good at something. Notice it out loud.

Work the room by helping other people work the room

How to Work a Room, Susan RoAne (1988)

RoAne's insight is that the most magnetic person at any event isn't the one collecting cards. It's the one making introductions.

Walk into the reception looking for someone standing alone, and bring them into a conversation. You'll be remembered by two people instead of forgotten by twenty.

Build trust through reliability

The Effective Executive, Peter Drucker (1967)

Drucker's real subject is dependability — becoming someone whose word settles the question.

This is where many relationships quietly die. Not in a blowup, but in a callback that took four days, a document that arrived Tuesday instead of Monday. Reliability is boring and it is the entire foundation.

Understand influence without becoming manipulative

Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion, Robert Cialdini (1984)

Cialdini documented why people say yes: reciprocity, consistency, social proof, authority. The mechanics are neutral. The intent is not.

The same principle that helps a good broker communicate real value helps a bad one sell a bad deal. Learn them so you recognize when they're being run on you.

Maintain emotional control

Meditations, Marcus Aurelius (c. 170–180 AD); How to Stop Worrying and Start Living, Dale Carnegie (1948)

Eighteen centuries apart, same conclusion: your steadiness is part of your professional reputation.

Deals go sideways. Financing falls out. The client who stays calm on that call is the one everybody wants in the room next time. People bring their hardest problems to the steadiest person they know.

Stay in touch without always selling

Never Eat Alone, Keith Ferrazzi (2005)

Ferrazzi built a career on staying connected before he needed anything. The discipline is keeping contact separate from conversion.

If every message you send contains an ask, you've trained people to brace when your name appears. Send the article. Congratulate the promotion. Let ninety percent of your contact carry no agenda at all.

Create memorable experiences

Mr. Shmooze, Richard Abraham (2002)

Abraham's character doesn't win on information — he wins on how people feel in his company. Energy, attention, and small gestures that land because they're specific.

Nobody remembers your third email. They remember that you drove out for the topping-off, or sent the book you'd talked about with a note on the flyleaf. Specificity is what survives.

Where AI belongs in all of this

Use the tools. AI is genuinely good at preparation — catalog a portfolio, prepare intelligent questions, capture notes, track promises and next steps, research a person or company before a meeting. It's good at recall, at timing, at clearing the friction that used to eat a day. Let it.

What it cannot do is show up. It can't sit in a truck for two hours to walk a site nobody is paying you to walk. It can't hear that someone's voice changed when you asked about the refi. It can't be remembered.

The real risk isn't a bad email. AI tools make you feel like you've done the work. It hasn’t, you still need to get out there and make contact.

A practical routine

None of the above is complicated. It's just unglamorous and repeated.

Weekly

- Five calls with no agenda. No deck, no ask, no follow-up sequence.
- One introduction between two people who you think should know each other.
- One thing of value sent to someone who cannot return the favor.

Monthly

- Reconnect with three people you haven't spoken to in a year.
- Show up at one thing you don't have to attend.
- Review what you promised last month and confirm you delivered all of it.

Yearly

- Name your twenty most important relationships and be honest about where each one stands.
- Pick five to deepen deliberately.
- Read one of these books. There are thirteen listed here and they'll last you a decade.

Final thoughts

AI is a valuable tool. Use the tools. Verify the tools. Then go have lunch with somebody.

Two thousand years of the sharpest people who ever lived worked this problem, and they keep returning the same answer.

Show up. Give first. Keep your word. Repeat for years.

There was never a shortcut. And there still isn't.

Sources

- Abraham, Richard. *Mr. Shmooze: The Art and Science of Selling Through Relationships.* The Richard Abraham Company, 2002; Wiley edition, 2010.
- Carnegie, Dale. *How to Win Friends and Influence People* (1936); *How to Stop Worrying and Start Living* (1948).
- Marcus Aurelius. *Meditations* (c. 161–180 AD).
- RoAne, Susan. *How to Work a Room* (1988).

- Cialdini, Robert. *Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion* (1984).
- Covey, Stephen R. *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People* (1989).
- Drucker, Peter. *The Effective Executive* (1966).
- Burg, Bob. *Endless Referrals* (McGraw-Hill, 1993; revised editions 1998 and 2005).
- Mackay, Harvey. *Dig Your Well Before You're Thirsty* (1997).
- Ferrazzi, Keith. *Never Eat Alone* (2005, revised 2014).
- Burg, Bob, and John David Mann. *The Go-Giver* (2007).
- Grant, Adam. *Give and Take* (2013).